BCE. The term India existed in Old English (5th century CE) and features in the King James Bible. And the word isn't just in English. The Dutch East India Company was established in 1602, at about the same time as the British one in 1599. Their colonisation of the 'East Indies' gave Indonesia its name. As a name for our subcontinent, 'India' long precedes the British Raj.

But even if, for argument's sake, the natives were right that 'India' came with the British, it would still be wrong to dump it in favour of the desi 'Bharat'. It was Mohammed Ali Jinnah, the founder of Pakistan, who wanted our country named either Bharat or Hindustan, to deny it any right to claim the storied legacy of the name India, to which he felt his own state had equal claim. At the same time, our first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, insisted on retaining the name 'India' for the newly independent country, in the face of resistance from nativists who wanted it renamed 'Bharat', in order to ensure that we were seen as the successor state to the India that had enjoyed membership of the United Nations and the League of Nations. By retaining India, he ensured that Pakistan was just a seceding state, which had to apply afresh for international recognition.

There is also the undoubted fact that the name India has incalculable brand value built up over centuries. When a brand is mentioned, it carries with it a whole series of associations in the public mind, as well as expectations of how it will perform. A country isn't a soft drink or a cigarette, but its very name can conjure certain associations in the minds of others. This is why 'India' had value in the eyes of the world: it was a fabled and exotic land, much sought after by travellers and traders for centuries, the "jewel in the crown" of Her Britannic Majesty Victoria, whose proudest title was that of "Empress of India". Nehru wanted people to understand that the India he was leading was heir to that precious heritage. He wanted, in other words, to hold on to the brand, though it was not a term he was likely to have employed.

This is why we should continue to use both words rather than relinquish our claim to a name redolent of history, a name that is recognised around the world. Of course, ultimately the only real guarantee of any brand's continued worth is the actual performance of the product or service it stands for. But why be so foolish as to relinquish all the benefits of the India brand globally when we can enjoy them without giving up the strength of "Bharat" at home?

The final clincher: Since our neighbours, the Arabs and the Persians, pronounced 's' as 'h', it is also they who called the people across the Sindhu the 'Hindus'. So if the BJP rejects the name India, they will have to reject the name 'Hindu' by the same logic, since that is equally of foreign origin. No longer will they be able to demand of us all, "*Garv se kaho ki hum Hindu hain*". Etymologically, that is just the same as declaiming "*Garv se kaho ki hum Indian hain*"! Which all of us have been for too long, really, to waste any more time debating this utterly fatuous and juvenile proposition. ■

***– Shashi Tharoor** is an author and a Lok Sabha MP of the Congress*



By **SANJEEV SANYAL**

THE MAKING OF BHARATAVARSHA

THE RIG VEDA TELLS US HOW THE BHARATA TRIBE BUILT INDIA'S FIRST KNOWN EMPIRE AND CREATED A MODEL OF ASSIMILATION RATHER THAN IMPOSITION. THUS, THEY CAME TO LEND THEIR NAME TO A WHOLE CIVILISATION